STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

ENGAGEMENT: THE 2026 DATA

One worker in five worldwide is engaged. Why Albania comes out above the average, why Europe is last, and what goes with engagement in a team.

32% of employees in Albania are engaged, a three-year average to 2025. World: 20%. Europe: 12%.

GALLUP, 2026

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NO. 09 · PEOPLE

In this issue

Engagement is neither happiness nor satisfaction. Gallup uses the word for people who are involved in and enthusiastic about their work and workplace. Here we read the 2026 data and ask what a manager can do with them.

The April 2026 report shows the second decline in a row worldwide, mostly among managers. Albania, at 32%, comes out above the world average and far above Europe. Gallup's meta-analysis of 183,806 work units links high engagement with fewer absences, fewer accidents and more profit. The data show an association; they do not establish cause.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

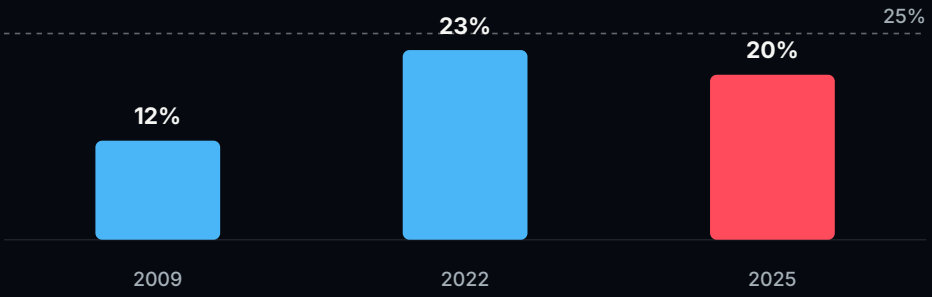
Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

One worker in five

In 2025, 20% of the world's employees were engaged, according to Gallup: the lowest level since 2020, after two years of decline.

ENGAGED EMPLOYEES WORLDWIDE



Share of employees worldwide who were engaged in each year shown, as Gallup measured it (State of the Global Workplace 2026).

The decline comes mostly from managers: their engagement fell from 31% in 2022 to 22% in 2025, while among employees without a management role it moved from 20% to 19%. Issue 1 of this review covers it at length.

31%
engaged in the US in 2025

17%
actively disengaged in the US in 2025

36%
the US peak, in 2020

OUR READING

When managers' engagement falls, the team feels it before the survey shows it.

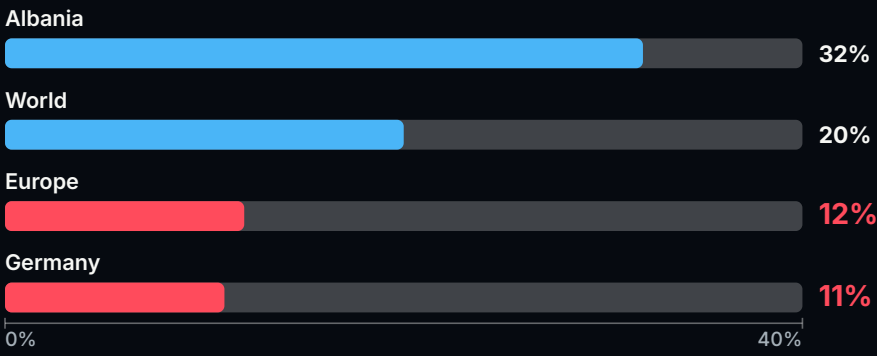
Sources: Gallup, 2026; Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026

THE NUMBERS

Albania
above the average

In the country data, Albania has 32% engaged. Europe, at 12%, is the lowest region in the world.

ENGAGED EMPLOYEES, 2025



Share of employees engaged. Albania, Germany and Europe are 2023–2025 averages; the world is 2025 alone, so the comparison is approximate.

11% → 32%
Albania, from 2012 to 2025 (three-year averages)

63%
in Albania say it is a good time to find a job (Europe 57%, world 52%)

Albania, Germany and Europe are averages of 2023–2025; the world figure is 2025 alone, so that comparison is approximate.

OUR READING

Where jobs are easy to find, high engagement guarantees nothing, which gives a manager one more reason to work at keeping good people.

Sources: Gallup, State of the Global Workplace: Albania, 2026; Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2026; Gallup, State of the Global Workplace: Germany, 2026

THE MODEL

Four levels of engagement

Gallup measures engagement with 12 elements and arranges them in four levels, from basic needs to growth. Each level builds on the one below; Gallup says the needs are met in sequence.

01	02	03	04
Basic needs	**Contribution**	**Teamwork**	**Growth**
Knowing what is expected and having what the work needs.	Doing what you do best, being noticed, having someone who cares.	Your opinion counts, the purpose means something, colleagues care about quality.	Someone talks with you about your progress, and you can learn.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, THE FOUR LEVELS IN ONE WAREHOUSE SHIFT

Basic needs	The plan for the day is on the board and the scanners are charged.
Contribution	The lead names yesterday's good work in the briefing.
Teamwork	When someone says a step does not work, it is written down and taken up.
Growth	Each month, everyone learns one new task in the warehouse.

An editors' illustration, not drawn from any one company.

OUR READING

Many engagement programmes start at the top, with values and events. Gallup's model suggests starting at the bottom: does everyone know what is expected today, and do they have what they need to do it?

Source: Gallup, 2026

The descriptions are in our words; the Q12 questions belong to Gallup and are not reproduced.

WHY IT MATTERS

What moves with engagement

Gallup's meta-analysis (11th edition, 2024) compares work units in the top quarter of engagement with those in the bottom quarter. The medians:

736 studies	**347** organisations in 90 countries	**183,806** work units
−78% absenteeism	**−63%** safety incidents	**−32%** quality defects
+23% profitability	**+18%** sales productivity	**−21%** turnover, in high-turnover organisations
−28% shrinkage (theft)	**+10%** customer loyalty	**+70%** employees thriving in their wellbeing

These are medians and links across units, not proof that engagement causes them. Except for wellbeing, the outcome data come from the organisations' own records.

OUR READING

A shift lead sees engagement less in an annual survey than in who comes on time, who reports the mistake and who stays.

Source: James K. Harter et al., Gallup, 2024

HOW IT IS MEASURED

The team's pulse

Gallup's survey needs permission and method. A manager can still keep a short pulse in their own words, and use it to open a conversation. It should never turn into a grade.

1. **No names**
   Cards are collected without names; results are seen only for the whole team.
2. **Start at the bottom**
   If the statements on basic needs score low, start there, not with growth.
3. **One conversation, one change**
   Talk with the team about the lowest statement and choose one thing to change.
4. **Repeat**
   After three months, with the same statements.

> HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A TEAM OF TWELVE
> Average scores: basic needs 4.2, contribution 3.1, teamwork 3.8, growth 2.6. Growth is lowest while the basics hold, so the team agrees on one monthly conversation about progress. (Made-up numbers.)

OUR READING

A pulse that brings no change teaches the team to stop answering.

The four steps are our proposal.

More in the essay — Leading people without losing the person

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

Eight statements for the team

Two statements for each level, in our words. Everyone rates them without a name, from 1 to 5.

1 = not at all · 5 = completely		1	2	3	4	5
01	At the start of the shift I know what matters most today.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
02	When I lack something for the work, I get it without losing time.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
03	This week someone noticed a good piece of my work.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
04	My lead knows what helps me work well.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
05	When I say something is not working, I am heard.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
06	In our team we help each other when someone falls behind.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
07	This month I learned something that makes my work easier.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
08	I know what I need to learn for the next step.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

After the card

1. Find the level with the lowest scores.
2. Ask the team what would raise it, and listen.
3. Change one thing, then repeat the card after three months.

The statements are in our words, grouped by Gallup's four levels; they are not the Q12 questions. Use the card for the team, never to rate a person.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

State of the Global Workplace 2026
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/349484/state-of-the-global-workplace.aspx

State of the Global Workplace: Albania
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/704378/state-global-workplace-albania-country-level-data.aspx

State of the Global Workplace: Germany
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/705434/state-global-workplace-germany-country-level-data.aspx

Employee Engagement Declines From 2020 Peak
Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/701486/employee-engagement-declines-2020-peak.aspx

Gallup's Employee Engagement Survey: Ask the Right Questions With the Q12 Survey
Gallup, 2026
https://q12.gallup.com/

The Relationship Between Engagement at Work and Organizational Outcomes: 2024 Q12 Meta-Analysis
James K. Harter et al., Gallup, 2024
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/321725/q12-meta-analysis-report.aspx

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html